



Worldwide Hospitality and Tourism Themes

Working together to leverage film tourism: collaboration between the film and tourism industries

Simon Hudson

Article information:

To cite this document:

Simon Hudson, (2011), "Working together to leverage film tourism: collaboration between the film and tourism industries", *Worldwide Hospitality and Tourism Themes*, Vol. 3 Iss 2 pp. 165 - 172

Permanent link to this document:

<http://dx.doi.org/10.1108/17554211111123023>

Downloaded on: 21 February 2016, At: 05:49 (PT)

References: this document contains references to 24 other documents.

To copy this document: permissions@emeraldinsight.com

The fulltext of this document has been downloaded 2158 times since 2011*

Users who downloaded this article also downloaded:

W. Glen Croy, (2011), "Film tourism: sustained economic contributions to destinations", *Worldwide Hospitality and Tourism Themes*, Vol. 3 Iss 2 pp. 159-164 <http://dx.doi.org/10.1108/17554211111123014>

Peter Bolan, Stephen Boy, Jim Bell, (2011), ""We've seen it in the movies, let's see if it's true": Authenticity and displacement in film-induced tourism", *Worldwide Hospitality and Tourism Themes*, Vol. 3 Iss 2 pp. 102-116 <http://dx.doi.org/10.1108/17554211111122970>

Rafael Pires Basáñez, Hadyn Ingram, (2013), "Film and tourism: the imagined place and the place of the imagined", *Worldwide Hospitality and Tourism Themes*, Vol. 5 Iss 1 pp. 39-54 <http://dx.doi.org/10.1108/17554211311292439>



Access to this document was granted through an Emerald subscription provided by emerald-srm:380560 []

For Authors

If you would like to write for this, or any other Emerald publication, then please use our Emerald for Authors service information about how to choose which publication to write for and submission guidelines are available for all. Please visit www.emeraldinsight.com/authors for more information.

About Emerald www.emeraldinsight.com

Emerald is a global publisher linking research and practice to the benefit of society. The company manages a portfolio of more than 290 journals and over 2,350 books and book series volumes, as well as providing an extensive range of online products and additional customer resources and services.

Emerald is both COUNTER 4 and TRANSFER compliant. The organization is a partner of the Committee on Publication Ethics (COPE) and also works with Portico and the LOCKSS initiative for digital archive preservation.

*Related content and download information correct at time of download.



Working together to leverage film tourism: collaboration between the film and tourism industries

Film tourism

Simon Hudson

University of South Carolina, South Carolina, Columbia, USA

165

Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this paper is to show how an increasing number of film and tourism industry stakeholders are working together with the dual goals of attracting film production and then capitalizing on the subsequent exposure.

Design/methodology/approach – Recently published reports and articles related to the film industry and film tourism in particular are thoroughly reviewed.

Findings – Although most tourism organizations and film commissions have been slow to tap the potential benefits of film tourism, the examples highlighted show how partnerships between the two industries can be mutually beneficial.

Practical implications – If leveraged well, film tourism can have large economic gains for countries and regions. Destination marketing organizations should be working with film commissions and engaging in marketing activities at four distinct stages of a film's lifecycle; before production of a film, during production, during release of the film, and after release.

Originality/value – This is the first full film tourism paper to reflect on existing collaboration between the film and tourism industries.

Keywords Film, Tourism development

Paper type General review

Introduction

Despite the growing awareness of the relationship between film and tourism, as well as the anecdotal application of film tourism in destination marketing, the impacts of film tourism still appear to be under-appreciated. Though the effects of film tourism can have significant long-term benefits, many tourism organizations and film commissions have been slow to tap the potential benefits of film tourism, perhaps due to a lack of knowledge, research, or evidence that fully explains the potential of film tourism (Croy and Walker, 2003; Hudson and Ritchie, 2006). If leveraged well, film tourism can have large economic gains for countries and regions. In the UK, for example, around one in ten foreign visitors come as a result of seeing the country depicted in film, and their spending in 2006 amounted to 1.8 billion pounds sterling. As a result of this spending, around 20,000 jobs were supported in the UK, contributing an additional 900 million pounds to GDP (Oxford Economics, 2007).

But the potential of film tourism is all too often not fully recognized by destination marketing organizations (DMOs) who often do not exploit the “destination image enhancement” opportunities that exist through the medium of film (Bolan and Williams, 2008; Liou, 2010). Film commissions, too, have tended to ignore the film tourism phenomenon, focusing understandably on attracting film production, recognizing the significance of the film industry on local economies (Gasher, 1995; Weinstein and Clower, 2000; Coe, 2001; Turok, 2003). They usually have a short-term focus that



facilitates film production, concentrating solely on the immediate associated economic impacts (Croy and Walker, 2003; Thomas, 2008).

However, in the last decade, an increasing number of film and tourism industry stakeholders have begun to work together with the dual goals of attracting film production and then capitalizing on the subsequent exposure (Cynthia and Beeton, 2009). For the tourism industry, the benefits of film tourism are obvious, as witnessed by the UK data given above, but in the film industry there is a growing realization that leveraging film tourism can bring significant benefits to the local film industry.

Initially, cooperation with the tourism industry can help off-set costs during filming. The South African tourism department, for example, helps visiting film scouts find locations and then provides technical support and accommodation for production staff. Other tourism stakeholders are more strategic in their support for film production. Destinations like Malta, Georgia, Singapore and Iceland offer extra credit to producers if the production is going to be good for tourism. The Malta Tourism Authority, for example, offers a cash incentive, as well as logistical support, to film and television productions that depict “Malta as Malta”. Working closely with the Malta Film Commission, the authority also hosts press trips to promote the island as a “movie location”. This type of activity increases exposure, and further establishes the destination as “film friendly” and is therefore beneficial to the local film commission. Malta’s ambition is for film to become a serious niche sector of its economy. And it is not just the DMOs that are offering these incentives. Location Flanders, for example, offers special grants to productions in which the stories are set in Flanders and if the productions will have a favourable impact on the tourism economy (just as *In Bruges* did for this northern part of Belgium in 2008).

Other destinations that have become known as “film friendly” – partly due to cooperation between the tourism and film industries – are New Zealand and Australia. New Zealand capitalized on the success of *The Lord of the Rings* in its marketing campaigns (Buchmann *et al.*, 2009) with the film providing a good reason for government agencies (including Tourism NZ, Trade NZ and Film NZ) to work together on a co-ordinated strategy. The government invested up to US\$18.6 million on projects to promote New Zealand in the wake of the film, and the Prime Minister, Helen Clark, personally endorsed the branding of New Zealand as the home of *The Lord of the Rings* and Middle Earth. She even appointed a special *The Lord of the Rings* Minister to oversee the campaign that included a huge international media program and numerous events leveraging off the film, such as those featuring New Zealand food and wine. Activities planned around the release of the film moved beyond the scenery to promote sectors such as art, crafts, food, wine, music and fashion.

Australian tourism officials have also been very proactive in the past in forging relationships with the film industry, collaborating with Disney on *Finding Nemo*, being the first DMO to try promotion through an animated film. More recently, Tourism Australia invested millions of dollars promoting their country on the tailcoats of the blockbuster *Australia* that debuted in cinemas in November 2008. *Australia* was an epic movie starring two of Hollywood’s biggest stars, Nicole Kidman and Hugh Jackman, and was directed by Baz Luhrmann. The new branding campaign, conceived and produced by Luhrmann himself, ran for several months in tourism Australia’s international markets, coinciding with the world-wide marketing and release of the movie. With its dramatic locations and stunning cinematography, Australian tourism officials were

hoping that the movie would make audiences all over the world fall in love with Australia and help to make the country a highly fashionable tourism destination. Although the movie was not a huge success, research carried out by Tourism Australia after the event suggested that the \$40 million spent on the “Come Walkabout” branding campaign (still in use in some countries in 2010) was a sound investment, and resonated particularly well in the US and the UK markets (Tourism Australia, 2009).

Stages of collaboration

DMOs can work with film commissions and engage in marketing activities at four distinct stages; before production, during production, during release of the film, and after release (Hudson and Ritchie, 2006).

1. Before production

Previous research has shown that collaborative campaigns between the film and the tourism industry are the most powerful way to induce film tourists (Grihault, 2003), especially if these partnerships are forged in the pre-production stage (Hudson and Ritchie, 2006). In the Bahamas, where the film commission is under the auspices of the ministry of tourism, the ministry is involved immediately it receives a script. It invested \$16 million (much of it in-kind) on the Pierce Brosnan film, *After the Sunset*, in order to ensure maximum exposure for the island. The Bahamas realised the potential of promoting tourism through films after the Beatles filmed *Help!* there in 1964. Now it gets involved in films right from the outset. And it is important to remember that it is not just films that attract tourists. Television series can also have a major impact on destination brand awareness. The OC, for example, shot in Orange county, California was a great branding tool for the county. Reality television can also attract tourists as witnessed by programs like *Survivor*. Several countries have actively lobbied for the privilege of hosting *Survivor*, including Gabon in West Africa which provided the setting for the show's 17th outing in 2008. Governments are increasingly including reality television in their financial incentives (Stephens, 2010), aware that reality now accounts for 54 percent of all television in the US with more people watching reality franchises than blockbuster movies.

In the UK, VisitBritain is also very active pre-production and always encourages producers to make productions in their region. For example, it has been targeting Indian film producers for some time in the belief that they can be persuaded to use British locations for “Bollywood” films, and, thereby, generate significant economic benefits for Britain's tourism industry (Woodward, 2000). Indian films are massively popular throughout Southeast Asia, so featuring positive images of Britain is a very cost-effective way of achieving high-level brand exposure and recognition for British products and icons. VisitBritain has recognized that it is not always evident to audiences (especially for the Bollywood movies shown in India) that a British location has been used – sometimes a British location doubles for another place. So, VisitBritain works very closely with film distributors and other partners on tactical promotions to ensure that attention is drawn to these British locations and that maximum exposure is obtained (Woodward, 2000).

At the pre-production stage, it is important to assess carefully a film's merit in terms of its promotional value for target markets. Films that reflect an authentic image of the country and capture the essence of a place – whether it is scenery or cultural

content – tend to be the most successful. At this pre-production stage, it is also very important for locations to negotiate credits for being used in the film – even if the location is a backdrop for another. St James Court Hotel in London demanded – and received – a credit when its courtyard was used in key scenes for *Howard's End*, something that was calculated as having given the hotel up to one million sterling of free publicity (Evans, 1999/2000). Negotiating simple end credits is standard practice in the industry but there is room for more dynamic exposure by negotiating animated credits or marketing features for locations. Overall, at the pre-production stage, the ability to be flexible, to recognize promotional opportunities and to act in anticipation of demand, is critical in maximizing the potential benefits of film tourism (NZIER, 2002).

2. During production

During production of a film – especially one that is high profile – there are many opportunities to generate publicity for a location. Working with the producer's publicist throughout the film production process is one way to ensure consistent messaging about the location and its merits as a destination. During the filming of *The Lord of the Rings*, for example, media clippings mentioned that the film was being shot in New Zealand, providing important early linkage between the film and the location. The film's stars also provided endorsement of New Zealand, heaping praise on the island and helping promote everything from Wellington's fashion to its cafes. VisitBritain works hard to get endorsements from Bollywood actors for British locations, recognizing that they can add tremendous kudos to a destination and bring it higher up on the agenda of "must-see" destinations for many Indians and Asians (Woodward, 2000).

DMOs can also assist visiting film production on location. Producers of the *Thirsty Traveler* television series, for example, contact tourist boards in the various locations they would like to film well in advance of production (Bodnarchuk, 2004). They ask for help with accommodation, vehicles, crew meals, guides and translators, and film permits. They find some DMOs more accommodating than others, but would still rather deal with DMOs than film commissions. The Korean National Tourism Organization, for example, was extremely helpful in all aspects of pre-production and on-location filming, employing dedicated staff to assist with every aspect of the production. Historic Scotland also provided excellent logistical support, helping with filming in castles, waiving film permit fees, providing on-location guiding services and providing parking permits and spaces. Some will ask for a specific deal in return – Quebec Tourism provided fee-free Betacam footage in exchange for a credit – whereas others just understand the advantages of exposure that the program will give their destination.

In 2004, the Canadian Tourism Commission provided financial assistance with airfares and helicopter filming for a BBC London television program that featured Canada in three of eight episodes. The production, called *The Challenge*, focused on the polar challenge in Nunavut (an endurance race to the North Pole), the Yukon River Quest, and the Transat Quebec-St Malo sail race across the Atlantic. The value of media coverage was estimated at hundreds of thousands of dollars (Canadian Tourism Commission, 2004). The London office of the Canadian Tourism Commission has also worked with the UK's top breakfast TV programme, GMTV, to film two eight-minute specials on Quebec's whale-watching opportunities. GMTV has monthly viewers of 25 million, nearly 50 percent of the UK population.

3. Before release

DMOs can also develop marketing partnerships and prepare marketing material in advance of a film's release. Early in 2005, VisitBritain collaborated with Sony and Columbia Pictures in advance of the release of *Closer*, a movie filmed in London starring Jude Law, Julia Roberts and Clive Owen. On the VisitBritain web site, visitors could download a *Closer* movie map that showed the "many iconic London locations used in filming". Locations and attractions used in the film also collaborated in the marketing initiative. The London Aquarium, for example, had a printable 20 percent discount voucher on the side of the map. The VisitBritain site also had a direct link to Sony Pictures who, in turn, were advertising the *Closer* movie map on their home page.

In the same year in Canada, marketers from Yukon tourism and culture partnered with French and Italian distributors of the film *Le Dernier Trappeur*. Although the film was made in English, it was dubbed into French, Italian and German for distribution in those strong markets for Yukon's tourism industry. The film was seen as a viable investment in strengthening awareness of the destination with the scenic qualities of the film and the exotic nature of the lifestyle portrayed in the story line. Yukon's tourism marketing branch negotiated credits to appear right at the beginning of the film, making it clear to viewers that the film was shot in the Yukon. Together with industry partners including the federal government, over CDN\$60,000 was invested to co-brand Yukon and Canadian travel destinations with the film's distribution in Europe. The movie's web site had a link on its home page to a description of the Yukon with links under "partners" to both tourism Yukon and the Canadian Tourism Commission.

4. After release

The period of time during and following the film's release is when many DMOs get involved in marketing activities related to film tourism. At this stage, the challenge for DMOs is to convert the audience's interest in a film into a commitment for a future visit and capitalize on additional visitors brought through film. The Tourism Authority of Thailand (TAT), for example, heavily advertised its attractions during release of the film *The Beach*. The marketing campaign included a substantial amount of joint activity with Twentieth-Century Fox, and aimed to capitalize on the expected further popularity of Thai beaches in the wake of the film. In addition to advertising heavily in cinemas, TAT sent UK journalists and travel agents on familiarization trips and promoted awareness campaigns including financing a holiday prize on a BBC television game show with a themed quiz.

Promoting the destination during the actual screening of the film is another way to attract attention to a destination. The Scottish tourist board distributed direct response postcard adverts in cinemas that were screening *Braveheart*, inviting viewers to send for information on "Braveheart country." Another example of a destination attracting media attention during release of a film came at the beginning of 2002. Newfoundland's Ministry of Tourism partnered with the Canadian Tourism Commission in London, Air Canada, Vision and Buena Vista Productions to launch the movie *The Shipping News* at a gala event in London. The movie was based on E. Annie Proulx's Pulitzer Prize-winning book and took place in Newfoundland. The London screenings presented the film to UK tour operators and media.

Destinations often produce "destination guides" that are used alongside a film's release at the various release windows. New Zealand, for example, included a destination guide

along with *The Lord of the Rings* box set. Movie maps have also been found to be successful as part of a film tourism marketing campaign. VisitBritain produced its first movie map campaign in 1996, sponsored by Vauxhall. It featured 200 film and TV locations around Britain from 60 years of British film history, and quickly became its most successful printed product. Other marketing activities can include guided tours and film walks. Journey Latin America, a tour operator in the UK, pre-empted the film *Motorcycle Diaries* by organizing a three-week *Motorcycle Diaries* tour from Buenos Aires to Lima. The tour operator worked with the UK film distribution company Pathe which organized two private advanced screenings for the tour operator aimed at travel journalists.

Finally, a good example of cooperation between players in the film and tourism industries to leverage film tourism came in the summer of 2010 when Sony Pictures teamed up with STA Travel, Lonely Planet and Borders. The objective was to leverage the film *Eat, Pray, Love*, based on Elizabeth Gilbert's best-selling memoir in which the author embarks on journey across the world on a quest for self-discovery. *Lonely Planet* created a dedicated web site, with recommendations for sightseeing and lodging, and STA Travel advertised a contest for a 21-day trip to the three countries featured in the book – Italy, India and Indonesia. STA Travel was even named as Sony's "official" travel partner in promoting the movie, as a number of hotels, tour companies and even guidebook publishers jumped on the bandwagon, offering everything from do-it-yourself itineraries to luxury trips based on the film. Fans of the book have apparently been following in her footsteps ever since it was first published in 2006.

Conclusion

Despite the examples above, and the fact that many destinations have acknowledged the potential of film tourism and how it can create a powerful destination image, few get involved in leveraging the phenomenon, often due to budget constraints or the absence of a measurable return on investment. Others are concerned about retaining control over how and to whom the destination is presented through films and television series (O'Connor *et al.*, 2008). Ultimately, a destination could contract producers to make films that portray the destination in a favourable light. However, such programming should not appear as one long advertisement for tourism (Cohen, 1986). A film that viewers perceive as simply a commercial vehicle for marketing tourism will lose credibility and may even create a negative image towards the country.

Film commissions, too, could be more strategic in leveraging the benefits of film tourism. Some, like the Swedish Film Commission, are organizing special conferences to understand the phenomenon in more detail. But like DMOs, most commissions have extremely limited budgets, and, as a result, have to outsmart rather than outspend the competition in order to attract production (Hudson and Tung, 2010). But cooperative marketing can be very powerful (Cai, 2002) and the examples above show how partnering with the tourism industry cannot only off-set costs, but also establish a region as "film friendly". This outcome is a win-win for both tourism and film industries.

References

- Bodnarchuk, M. (2004), Grasslands Entertainments, Personal Interview, 25 January.
- Bolan, P. and Williams, L. (2008), "The role of image in service promotion: focusing on the influence of film on consumer choice within tourism", *International Journal of Consumer Studies*, Vol. 32, pp. 382-90.

- Buchmann, A., Moore, K. and Fisher, D. (2009), "Experiencing film tourism", *Annals of Tourism Research*, Vol. 37 No. 1, pp. 229-48.
- Cai, L.A. (2002), "Cooperative branding for rural destinations", *Annals of Tourism Research*, Vol. 29 No. 3, pp. 720-42.
- Canadian Tourism Commission (2004), "Canada is up to the challenge, Vancouver", available at: <http://canadatourism.com/en/ctc/ctx/ctxnews/search.newsbydateform.cfm>. (accessed 19 May 2008).
- Coe, N.M. (2001), "A hybrid agglomeration? The development of a Satellite-Marshallian Industrial District in Vancouver's film industry", *Urban Studies*, Vol. 38 No. 10, pp. 1753-75.
- Cohen, J. (1986), "Promotion of overseas tourism through media fiction", in Joseph, W.B. and Moutinho, L. (Eds), *Tourism Services Marketing: Advances in Theory and Practice*, Conference Series, Vol. 2, American Marketing Association and Cleveland state University, Cleveland, Ohio, OH, pp. 229-37.
- Croy, W.G. and Walker, R.D. (2003), "Rural tourism and film – issues for strategic regional development", in Hall, D. and Mitchell, M. (Eds), *New Directions in Rural Tourism*, Ashgate, Aldershot.
- Cynthia, D. and Beeton, S. (2009), "Supporting independent film production through tourism collaboration", *Tourism Review International*, Vol. 13 No. 2, pp. 113-9.
- Evans, M. (1999/2000), "A path to stardom: opportunities from film tourism", *Insights*, Vol. 11 No. 3, p. A81.
- Gasher, M. (1995), "The audiovisual locations industry in Canada: considering British Columbia as Hollywood North", *Canadian Journal of Communications*, Vol. 20 No. 2.
- Grihault, N. (2003), "Film tourism – the global picture", *Travel & Tourissssm Analyst*, Vol. 5, pp. 1-22.
- Hudson, S. and Ritchie, J.R.B. (2006), "Promoting destinations via film tourism: an empirical identification of supporting marketing initiatives", *Journal of Travel Research*, Vol. 44 No. 4, pp. 1-10.
- Hudson, S. and Tung, V.W.S. (2010), "'Lights, camera, action...!' Marketing film locations to Hollywood", *Marketing Intelligence & Planning*, Vol. 28 No. 2, pp. 188-205.
- Liou, D.-Y. (2010), "Beyond Tokyo Rainbow Bridge: destination images portrayed in Japanese drama affect Taiwanese tourists' perception", *Journal of Vacation Marketing*, Vol. 16 No. 1, pp. 5-15.
- NZIER (2002), "Scoping the lasting effects of *The Lord of the Rings*", A Report to the New Zealand Film Commission, New Zealand Institute of Economic Research, Wellington. April.
- O'Connor, N., Flanagan, S. and Gilbert, D. (2008), "The integration of film-induced tourism and destination branding in Yorkshire, UK", *International Journal of Tourism Research*, Vol. 10 No. 5, pp. 423-37.
- Oxford Economics (2007), *The Economic Impact of the UK Film Industry*, Oxford Economics, Oxford.
- Stephens, J. (2010), "Keeping it real", *Locations Magazine*, 12 January, pp. 78-83.
- Thomas, L. (2008), *The Qualitative and Quantitative Benefits of film-induced Tourism in Georgia*, Georgia Film, Music & Digital Entertainment Office, Georgia.
- Tourism Australia (2009), "'Come Walkabout' ad wins prestigious Clio Award", 16 May available at: http://media.australia.com/en-au/mediareleases/default_1829.asp. (accessed 12 August 2010).

- Turok, I. (2003), "Cities, clusters and creative industries: the case of film and television in Scotland", *European Planning Studies*, Vol. 11 No. 5, pp. 549-65.
- Weinstein, B.L. and Clower, T.L. (2000), "Filmed entertainment and local economic development: Texas as a case study", *Economic Development Quarterly*, Vol. 14 No. 4, pp. 384-94.
- Woodward, I. (2000), "Why should the UK's tourism industry be interested in 'Bollywood' films?", *Insights*, Vol. 12, pp. A23-6.

Corresponding author

Simon Hudson can be contacted at: shudson@hrsm.sc.edu

This article has been cited by:

1. Serena Volo, Anna Irimiás. 2015. Film Tourism and Post-Release Marketing Initiatives: a Longitudinal Case Study. *Journal of Travel & Tourism Marketing* 1-17. [[CrossRef](#)]
2. Simon Hudson, Vincent Tung. 2015. Appealing to Tourists via Branded Entertainment: from Theory to Practice. *Journal of Travel & Tourism Marketing* 1-15. [[CrossRef](#)]